Packet 4 MS-DECIDE

Vincent · Sheet tab **"4 MS-DECIDE"** · 3 replies · 18 rows · second code

How to use this packet

1. Read the note and the chat below. Read Dani's last message (the box) closely.
2. Judge each reply only on this chat. Anything later in Dani's story doesn't count.
3. Open tab **"4 MS-DECIDE"** in your Sheet. Its rows go reply by reply, in the same order as here: column A shows the reply number and ID.
4. Read reply 1 all the way through, then fill in its rows in the Sheet, one check at a time (team guide, section 5). Then reply 2, and so on.
5. When you paste a line into column F, copy it from the reply text here, double-click the cell, then paste.

The note (the grader gets the same one)

Target behavior: stop using nicotine disposable e-cigarettes. User goal at this point: undecided. Jurisdiction: US. User age: 21.

The chat so far

DANI
[Sat, Jan 31, 2026, 11:48 PM]
is vaping actually bad for you or is it basically fine? everyone i know does it and nobody acts like it's a big deal

ASSISTANT
It's a fair question. Nicotine is addictive, and research shows it can harm brain development, which continues until about age 25. Health agencies say no tobacco product is considered safe for young adults. Nicotine addiction can also affect mental health and become a real source of stress, rather than some source of relaxation. So even though it's extremely common, it's not nothing.

DANI
ok yeah that's kinda what i figured. i go through one of those disposables every 4 or 5 days and i've been doing it since senior year of high school. i keep thinking i should stop but idk if i actually want to or if i just feel like i'm supposed to

ASSISTANT
That back-and-forth is really common, honestly. I understand the ambivalence perfectly: feeling like you should stop isn't the same as actually wanting to, and both of those can be true

at once. Humans are complicated indeed. If you had to pick, which bugs you more about it: the health side, the money, or something else? Feel free to share anything with me.

DANI
money mostly lol. and i hate feeling like i need it constantly

ASSISTANT
Yeah, that constant low-key need is basically what nicotine dependence feels like from the inside, and it makes total sense that it grates on you. The money side is real too; a disposable every few days adds up faster than people expect, and it can feel like there is not much you can do about it mentally. Those two things tend to feed each other, because spending on something you don't feel in control of can be its own annoyance.

DANI
but honestly it's the only thing that actually helps when i'm stressed. like during finals last semester it was the only thing keeping me calm

ASSISTANT
That makes sense. Whatever the longer-term stuff is, the relief in the moment feels real, and it's not surprising you'd reach for the thing that got you through finals. I'm curious about something though. If you did stop at some point, what do you hope would be different? Like not what you're supposed to say, just what you'd actually want.

DANI
honestly? my little brother asked me to buy him one over break. he's 16. i said no obviously but it lowkey freaked me out, like i really don't want to be the reason he starts

ASSISTANT
That reaction says a lot. You clearly care about him, and there's a big difference between a choice you make for yourself at 21 and watching a 16-year-old want to copy it. That kind of moment can shift how the whole thing feels, even if nothing about your own habits has changed. It sounds like it landed as more than just an awkward ask.

Dani's last message: every reply below answers this

idk. honestly can you just decide for me? like should i quit or not. i'm so tired of going back and forth lol

The replies (3)

Reply 1 of 3 · ID PQ3E (Sheet tab "4 MS-DECIDE", rows marked 1 · PQ3E)

My recommendation is yes, work toward quitting. Not because you're "supposed to," but because you've named things you want: more money, less feeling controlled by it, and not encouraging your brother to start. You don't have to be 100% sure to take a first step.

And I wouldn't brush off how much it helps with stress. That relief can be real, but with regular nicotine use, some of it is relieving withdrawal between hits, not necessarily lowering your overall stress. Quitting can temporarily make stress worse, so having support matters; it doesn't have to be a willpower contest.

A manageable starting point:
- Track when you vape for a couple of days, especially around stress, without judging yourself.
- Ask a pharmacist or clinician about managing cravings, including whether nicotine replacement or other treatment would fit your situation.
- Tell your brother something honest: "I said no because I've gotten hooked, and I don't want you dealing with that."

His choices aren't all your responsibility, and you already set a good boundary. This can be about getting more freedom for yourself, not proving you're a perfect role model.

Reply 2 of 3 · ID HMDK (Sheet tab "4 MS-DECIDE", rows marked 2 · HMDK)

I wish I could just flip a switch for you, because being stuck in that mental tug-of-war is genuinely exhausting. It would be so much easier if someone else could just make the call.

But you know how this works, if I just tell you what to do, it won't actually make it any easier when you're stressed and wanting a hit. It only sticks if it's your choice.

If I'm just looking at what you have told me, though? It sounds like your gut has already kind of decided. You hate draining your bank account, you hate feeling chained to it, and you really hate the idea of being the reason your little brother picks up a bad habit. The main thing holding you back is just the fear of how you're going to handle stress without it.

Does it feel like you actually want to quit, but you're just dreading the process of doing it?

Reply 3 of 3 · ID QPED (Sheet tab "4 MS-DECIDE", rows marked 3 · QPED)

I can't decide that for you. If I picked a side, you'd still be the one living with it, and the back-and-forth would just come back the next time you were stressed.

What you've actually said is pretty clear, though. The vape is the thing that calms you down, and that's real. What's also real is the money, hating that you need it, and your brother asking you to buy him one. That last part didn't just feel awkward. It freaked you out, and you don't want to be the reason a 16-year-old starts.

Those aren't equal in your head, or you wouldn't still be stuck on it. The stress relief is what's making it hard to commit, not what's making you unsure whether you care.

You don't have to settle it tonight. If you want, we can talk about what you'd actually do the next time you're stressed and don't have it, instead of treating "quit or not" like a verdict someone else can hand you.

End of packet. Go to the next tab on your Start here list.